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Career counseling

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1 What Career Counseling Is – And What Not

1.1 Career guidance versus career counseling and life design

Career counseling can be seen as a specific application of counseling psychology. At its core, counseling psychology is about supporting people to improve the assessment of themselves, their environment, and their current challenges as well as optimizing their experiences and their behavior (Gelso & Fretz, 2001). However, career counseling is often misconceived because the word "counseling" may imply to provide someone with expertise and knowledge. The word "counseling" could be interpreted in the way that clients get to know which professions would fit them best through information and advice given by the counselors. According to this conception, the counselor would provide information about certain professions and the labor market in general, based on his or her expertise. The counselor would also suggest specific occupations or career directions that fit the client. Such a view of career counseling is, however, not in accordance with a modern understanding of career counseling as described in this chapter. Rather, it corresponds to what should be named vocational or career *guidance*. In guidance, the client is treated as an object that ought to be analyzed (e.g., in terms of abilities, interests, personality) and for whom corresponding work environments and occupations ought to be identified. Vocational guidance is thus aiming to match the client with work that resembles his or her objective traits and abilities. In such an approach, the career counselor acts as an expert for assessment and information about the world-of-work. In contrast, modern approaches of career counseling speak of *life design* (Nota & Rossier, 2015; Savickas et al., 2009) or *career construction* (Savickas, 2013). According to these approaches, career counseling is about helping clients to construct a subjectively meaningful identity, to increase their self-reflection, and to help them create their career according to their personal identity and life story. It is important to note, however, that

the modern approach does not attempt to replace the traditional one. Rather, they are complementary to each other and co-exist in career counseling practice (Savickas, 2012).

After outlining some basic criteria that are typical for both career guidance and career counseling, in this chapter we will first present a counseling process that is aligned with more traditional approaches in career guidance, focusing on helping clients to make better career decisions. Second, we will describe a more modern approach of career counseling based on the life design paradigm. Finally, we will review research investing the effectiveness of career interventions to promote career development among diverse clients.

1.2 Four core characteristics of career guidance and counseling

Four core elements are typical characteristics of most forms of career guidance and counseling: (1) A focus on psychologically healthy clients; (2) a focus on client's resources and strengths; (3) a relatively short duration of the guidance/counseling process; and (4) considering the client in context (Gelso & Fretz, 2001). One important element of career guidance and counseling is the fact that it is not focused on people with pathological disorders (Gelso & Fretz, 2001). Rather, career guidance and counseling aims to deal with problems, challenges, and topics that every person could be confronted with during his or her lifetime (e.g., career undecidedness, unemployment, lack of knowledge about the labor market, job dissatisfaction). The concepts and interventions in career guidance and counseling are thus primarily based on helping psychologically healthy people (Gelso & Fretz, 2001). Also, empirical findings show that people suffering from serious psychological problems (e.g., depression, anxiety, or panic attacks) benefit less from career interventions than clients without these problems (Whiston & Rahardja, 2008). The counselor therefore needs to possess the competencies to recognize psychological disorders and to refer such clients to psychotherapy if needed. The therapy of psychological disorders is thus not a goal of career guidance or counseling nor does it belong to the sphere of typical competencies of a career counselor. An additional important feature of career guidance and counseling is that career counselors traditionally focus on clients' strengths and resources (Gelso & Fretz, 2001). In career guidance and counseling, it is assumed that every person possesses certain resources and strengths that can be activated and taken advantage of to enhance a positive development. One consequence of the combination of focusing on psychologically healthy clients as well as their resources and strengths is that career guidance and counseling interventions have typically a short duration. Efficacy studies showed that career interventions can already generate maximal efficacy with five to six sessions (Brown & Ryan Krane, 2000).

Another core aspect of career guidance and counseling is that counselors focus on the clients in context. Career guidance and counseling cannot be only about the individual but also needs to take into account how the individual interacts with the environment. Therefore, gaining clarity about personal interests, strengths, and goals is only one aspect of the guidance and counseling process. It is equally important to link these personal factors with the environment. This may be the more proximal social environment (e.g., how personal interests and goals are influenced by and influence the spouse of the client) as well as the more distal macro-environment such as the labor market (e.g., how personal interests and goals are shaped by and may be realized in the current labor market). This dual focus on the client and his or her environment implies that career guidance and counseling does not just require psychological competencies such as psychological assessment (Whiston, 2008) or motivational interviewing (Klonek, Wunderlich, Spurk, & Kauffeld, 2016; Rochat & Rossier, 2016). In addition, a profound knowledge about different educations, professions, and the labor market are important competencies for career counselors. As described above, giving expert advise to clients on these matters is not the core element of career counseling and more typical for career guidance. However, also in career counseling, a profound knowledge about the world-of-work is critical in order not to remain restricted to the individual and to sufficiently put the client, including his or her needs, aspirations, abilities, and limitations, in context.

2 Career Counseling for Better Career Decisions: The CIP Model

Ever since its emergence, career guidance has placed a strong emphasis to help people with their career decisions and to overcome career indecision (Hartung & Blustein, 2002). Until today, research into the environmental and personal factors that create career indecision (Gati, Krausz, & Osipow, 1996), examinations of different career decision-making styles and their effects on indecision (Gati & Levin, 2012), or strategies to cope with career indecision (Lipshits-Braziler, Gati, & Tatar, 2015), are an important foundation of vocational psychology and career guidance research and practice. These approaches more closely resemble guidance rather than counseling because they primarily aim at helping clients to make a career decision and finding an occupation that corresponds to their aspirations and opportunities. However, as we will elaborate below, more typical counseling activities (e.g., self-reflection and identity construction) can also be integrated into models that describe processes to improve client's career decision-making. In practice, there is hence no clear-cut distinction between processes of guidance and those of career counseling. For simplicity, we herein refer to models that

focus on helping clients with career decisions as counseling models and processes of career counseling.

One of the most prominent and frequently researched models to assist clients in making better career decisions is the cognitive information-processing approach (CIP) by (Sampson, Reardon, Peterson, & Lenz, 2004). The CIP postulates a model of career guidance and decision-making based on a general process of problem solving, represented in the CASVE circle (named after the starting letters of the five stages of the proposed process). The first stage of the CASVE Model is communication (C), followed by analysis (A), synthesis (S), valuing (V), and finally execution (E) (see Figure 1).

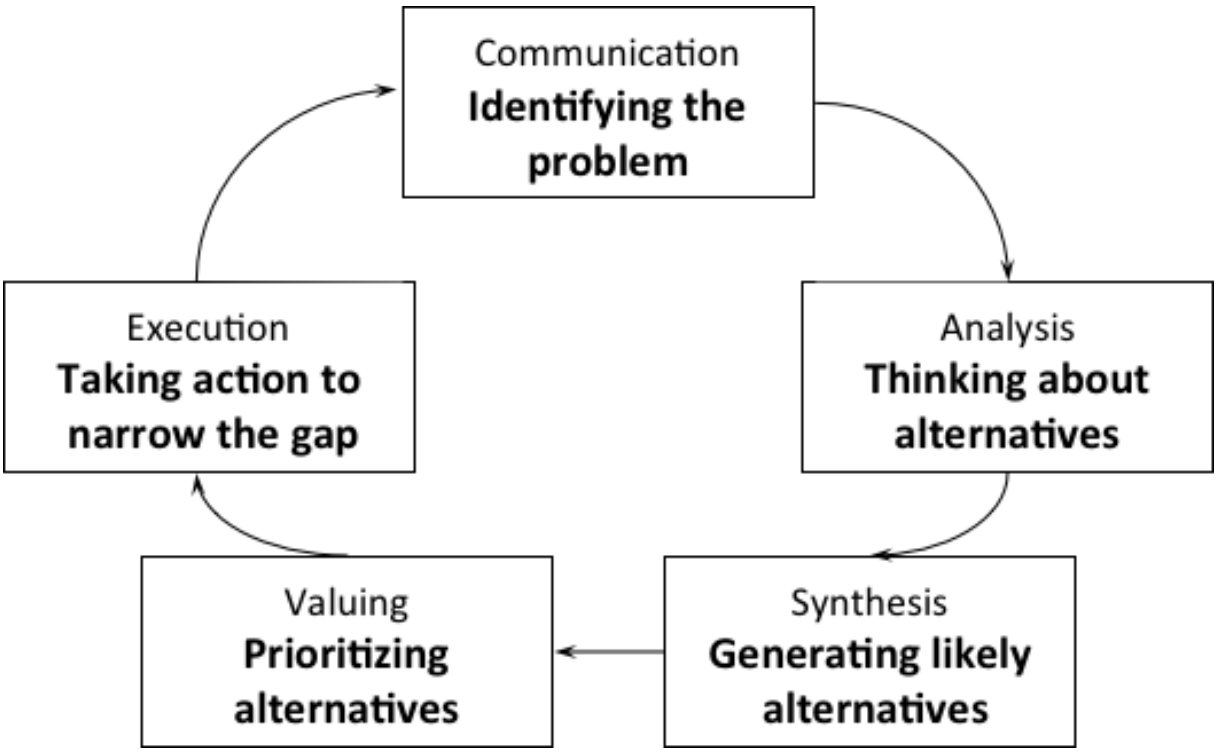

Figure 1: CASVE cycle of career counseling after (Sampson, Peterson, Lenz, & Reardon, 1992)

During the initial *communication* stage, the current situation of the client is assessed and the discrepancy between the current state and the desired state is clarified. Obtaining a clear understanding of the situation and the current difficulties and challenges of the client is the core task in this phase. Also, counselor and client should define specific and measurable goals for the counseling process as well as identify concrete steps and processes that are necessary to successfully realize the established counseling goals. In this first phase it is also important to build the foundation for a solid working alliance between the counselor and the

client that is marked by a clear understanding and mutual agreement upon the goals and the process of the counseling as well as respect, acceptance of the client, and empathy for his or her situation and actions.

During the subsequent stage of *analysis*, the client's self-awareness should be enhanced. Clients should receive help in enhancing their reflection about their own person and situation by applying for example psychological assessments (e.g., aptitude tests, interest inventories), structured interviews, or counseling techniques such as reformulation, summaries, or open questions. Additionally, this stage is about improving the client's knowledge about his or her vocational possibilities. For example, the counselor could provide the client with important information about the labor market or certain professions. In addition, the client could be encouraged and instructed to look for further career information and the counselor would help the client to evaluate and integrate this information and apply it to his or her current situation. The goals of this stage are to increase the client's self-awareness (interests, competencies, goals, personality, values, life situation, influences of the environment) as well as for the client to gain a broader knowledge of the working environment and specific vocational possibilities.

During the *synthesis* stage, possible solutions for the current career problem ought to be developed. This can be done in two steps: During the first step, as many solutions/career options as possible are developed. This process is called elaboration. Second, solutions/career options not corresponding to the client's identified key aspects of preferred options are filtered out. Through this so-called crystallization process, the client should reduce the large range of considered possibilities to a more manageable number of three to seven alternatives (Sampson et al., 2004). The main purpose of this stage is to get the client to identify a few career alternatives that are both realistic and corresponding to personal key preferences.

During the subsequent *valuing* stage, the options identified during the synthesis stage are evaluated in more detail. Advantages and disadvantages, chances and risk for the client and the environment (e.g., implication for one's spouse) should be discussed and written down in this stage. Based on such a detailed evaluation of each alternative, the client should then attempt to rank the alternatives according to his or her preferences and thereby determine a first and second choice. The main goals of this phase are thus to conduct a profound analysis of the different options and to make a decision about the next career step.

During the final *execution* stage, a plan or strategy to realize the choice taken is developed. Hereby, it is important to determine specific intermediate goals, to identify and

activate resources of the client, to develop strategies for handling drawbacks during the realization of the plan, and to point down concrete next action steps.

After this execution stage, there is a return to the communication stage. At this point, the client and counselor should evaluate if the client had overcome the formerly identified discrepancy between his or her current and desired state. Depending on the objectives of the counseling process, this evaluation can take place directly during the last counseling session or some months afterwards. If it turns out that the desired state has not been reached, the client and counselor can initiate a new counseling cycle by repeating the CASVE process.

Theoretically, this cycle can be completed during one counseling session. However, more likely, several sessions will be needed, especially for clients in complex career situations without sufficient environmental support (e.g., familial support, organizational support) or for clients with few competencies (e.g., job skills) or few internal resources (e.g., self-esteem). Moreover, it is possible that completing a single stage can take several sessions until the aims of this stage are satisfactorily achieved. Finally, it is left to say that this procedure is a prototype that does not have to be accomplished in exactly the same way as theoretically suggested. Depending on the client and the career issue, it is possible to change the chronology of the stages. For example, if a client already has clear ideas about possible professions but struggles with the decisions between these possibilities, it makes sense to start directly with the evaluation stage. If needed, it is also possible to return to earlier stages, for example, if it appears during the evaluation stage that the client needs more clarity about his or her personal preferences (analysis stage) or has insufficiently considered alternative possibilities (synthesis stage) (Sampson et al., 2004).

3 The Life Design Paradigm of Career Counseling

Life design has recently emerged as the new paradigm for career counseling in the 21st century (Savickas, 2012; Savickas et al., 2009). Its goal is to initiate activities that foster self-making, career construction, and that shape identities (Savickas, 2010). In sum, "life design, from the *project* perspective of social constructionism, views clients as *authors* who may be characterized by autobiographical *stories* and who may be helped to *reflect* on life *themes* with which to construct their careers" (Savickas, 2012, p. 17). According to Guichard (2015), three main factors explain the emergence and importance of the life design paradigm. First, Western societies have become a *liquid* modernity, because social structures and institutions no longer maintain their shape for a long time (i.e., solidify) but melt; thus, they cannot serve as frame of reference for individuals' behaviors any more. As a result,

individuals have to define by themselves what their lives mean to them. Put differently, their key personal values become the frames of reference that guide their behaviors and actions. Second, the organization of work and the distribution of jobs have changed from predictable career steps to flexible employment. Concretely, workers are gathered in networks for the duration of a specific assignment only, thus distinguishing between core and peripheral workers (i.e., long-term employees versus those hired when the economic market is good). Similarly, self-employment is increasing, and the responsibility of individuals' career trajectories has shifted from the organization to individuals. Third, scientific approaches to studying human behaviors have evolved: Behaviors are seen as less determined by individuals' past experiences, and humans are viewed as less unified but plural, thus in search for a life unity and meaning in life.

The life design paradigm reunites several narrative, constructivist, and social constructionism theories in career counseling. While the *constructivist* lens conceives that individuals make meaning of the world through their cognitive structures, the *social constructionism* lens sees individuals as co-constructing meaning through narratives and relationships (Hartung, 2013). Thus, reality is highly subjective, both at the individual (psychological constructivism) and collective (social constructionism) levels. Similarly, the *narrative perspective* focuses on careers as stories that define individuals' identities and provide meaning to their life trajectories (Del Corso & Rehfuss, 2011). In particular, three distinct perspectives that include narratives in career theory and intervention have been suggested (Hartung, 2013): career as meaning making (i.e., work as shaping life's meaning), career as a life theme (i.e., emerging from several career-related tasks), and career as a story. The latter form includes an author who tells the story, a specific context of the story, actions to reach a career goal, and resources used to achieve the goal (Hartung, 2013). Specifically, authors build stories about their career experiences because such stories allow them to fulfill personal motives related to purpose (i.e., objective or subjective), value and justification (e.g., being right or good), efficacy (i.e., control), and self-worth (Baumeister & Newman, 1994). Moreover, stories or self-narratives have been argued to help individuals reconstruct their identities during career transitions. Adopting a social constructionist view, Ibarra and Barbulescu (2010) suggested that workers engage in narrative identity work in interpersonal interactions: Based on others' feedback, individuals revise their stories in order to facilitate the expression of their new role identity, which, in turn, fosters adjustment to work transitions.

Further, one of the main theories involved in the life design paradigm is the *career construction theory* (Savickas, 2013). According to this theory, careers are constructed as

persons make choices in which their self-concepts are expressed, that is, as individuals derive meaning from their vocational behaviors. Specifically, career construction theory has highlighted three key features: (a) vocational personality (i.e., career-related abilities, needs, values, and interests, that foster individuals' reputation among a group of people and define *what* career they construct); (b) career adaptability (i.e., *how* individuals construct their careers, by being concerned about their future as workers, increasing personal control over their vocational future, displaying curiosity by exploring possible selves, and strengthening the confidence to pursue their career aspirations); and (c) life themes (i.e., *why* individuals construct their careers, the meaning behind making a specific career choice). As a result, careers are subjectively defined in a coherent and meaningful story that integrates various jobs. Put differently, career experiences from the past, present, and those expected in the future are reunited into a coherent life theme.

3.1 Career counseling interventions from a life design perspective

Overall, life design fosters career counseling interventions that make meaning of experiences (Hartung, 2013). This is achieved through autobiographical stories that link individuals' present with their past and future (Savickas, 2012). Specifically, four steps of a life design intervention have been identified (Savickas, 2012, 2015) (see Figure 2).

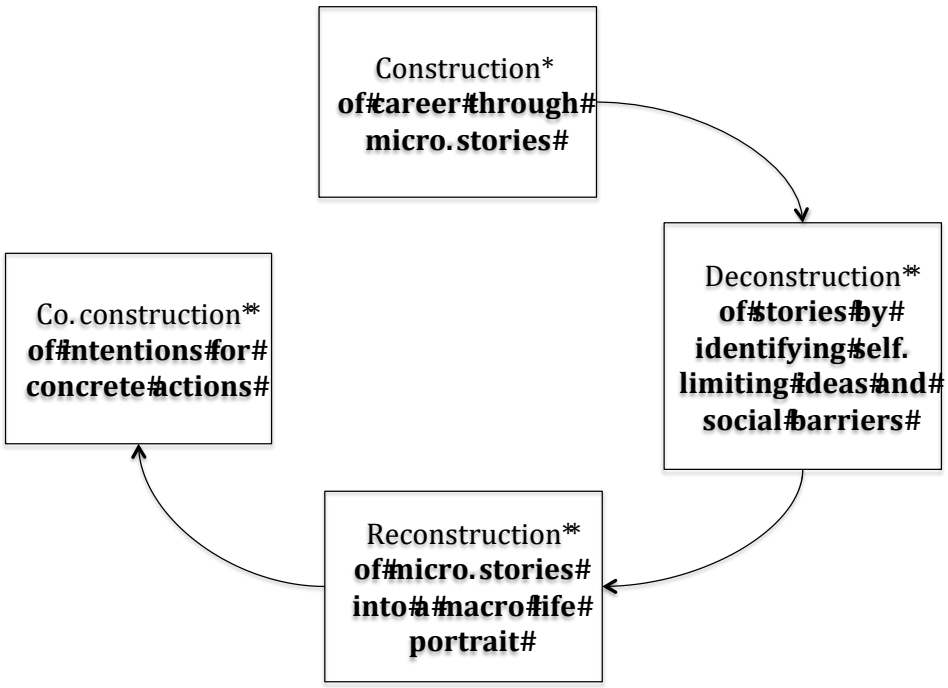

Figure 2: Career counseling steps in a life design approach (Savickas, 2012, 2015)

In the initial step of *construction*, career counselors aim to help a client construct his or her career through small stories. Concretely, Savickas (2015) suggested that after having explored clients' goals for the plot that they would like to co-construct in the career counseling process, career counselors asked five basic questions to foster stories about the origins of the self. Such questions explore clients' favorite book or movie, magazines or television shows, a motto, role models, and early memories. Further, career counselors need to ask clients to describe the circumstances under which they have been disconnected from the current episode of their story (i.e., a tension). Doing so, clients engage in narratives that shape such transitional discontinuations. Then, career counselors and clients *deconstruct* these stories by identifying self-limiting ideas and cultural barriers, which overcome more "life-enhancing alternatives" (Savickas, 2015, p. 143). The next step involves a *reconstruction* from micro- to macro-narratives, in order to rearrange stories into a life portrait (i.e., identity narrative). Finally, the life portrait is revised so that the identity narrative becomes clearer. Such revisions further provide the opportunity to explore clients' emotions and inner thoughts; and represent a means for coping with current problems. This last step is thus referred to as the *co-construction* of intentions given that a clearer life portrait can be more easily extended into the future and guide concrete actions.

In order to successfully conduct career counseling based on a life design approach, McIlveen (2015), highlighted that career counselors need both basic and enhanced competencies for life design. While the former include general competencies that are needed to conduct career guidance (e.g., psychological assessment, knowledge about the world-of-work), enhanced competencies are specific to the life-design paradigm and allow career counselors to reformulate clients' life story. First, *dialogical interpretation* can be related to conversations involved in the narrative process of an autobiographical storytelling, where career counselors adopt a specific position. Dialogical interpretation prevents career counselors from adopting the position of an expert, as it is the case of career guidance. By contrast, career counselors in life designing need to adopt the position of a committed co-editor or co-author, while the client is in the position of the editor or author. Put differently, the professional is the carpenter, while the client is the architect (Savickas, 2015). Second, the *ethic of critical reflexivity* represents a meta-competency that serves the development of professional skills and the production of new knowledge. Concretely, having space to reflect upon one's practice through supervision allows career counselors to deal with the levels of intimacy and trust necessary to work with clients in the position of a co-author.

4 Effectiveness of Career Interventions

4.1 General effectiveness

Given the variety of different approaches regarding how career guidance and counseling can be conducted, the question emerges if career interventions have in fact benefits for clients career development. Over the last decades, it has become well-established that career interventions generally have a positive effect on diverse outcomes of career development (for recent overviews see Hooley, 2014; Whiston & Noblin James, 2013). The first meta-analysis supporting the general effectiveness of career interventions was carried out by (Spokane & Oliver, 1983). They showed that clients receiving various kinds of guidance and counseling showed on average a greater improvement in outcome criteria such as career decidedness and career knowledge than 81% of a control group without an intervention. Later meta-analyses found a medium effect size of 0.34 for career choice courses for adults (Baker & Taylor, 1998), or mean effect sizes slightly above 0.30 across different career interventions (Brown & Ryan Krane, 2000; Whiston, Sexton, & Lasoff, 1998) regarding outcomes such as career decidedness, career exploration activities, or career knowledge. The strength of these effects is comparable with the effectiveness of other psychological interventions (Whiston, 2002). If we take a conservative value of the effectiveness of career interventions with an effect size of 0.30, this means that the average client after an intervention shows higher values in the assessed outcomes than 62% of a control group without an intervention (Whiston, 2002). In a review about the last 45 years of career intervention research, (Spokane & Nguyen, 2016) concluded that research has made great progress in studying the effectiveness of career interventions. However, they also indicate that, instead of only restrictedly focusing on results and outcomes of an intervention, an enhanced focus on the evaluation of the processes in career counseling is now necessary. Additionally, Spokane and Nguyen (2016) urge future interventions not only to be designed and evaluated for single clients or smaller groups but also for whole populations (for example school graduates, adults from a socially disadvantaged background). Finally, they point out that more research on long-term interventions, containing several points of intervention over time, will be needed. Despite these limitations in the current research and needs for future investigations into the processes and effectiveness of career interventions, one can state that diverse kinds of career interventions generally have a positive and significant effect on clients.

4.2 Effectiveness of specific types of career interventions

While the general effectiveness of career interventions has been confirmed, several meta-analyses suggest that different forms of career interventions are associated with different

levels of effectiveness (Oliver & Spokane, 1988; Whiston et al., 1998). Generally, individual counseling achieves the biggest effects per session. However, it is also the most expensive and time-consuming approach. Also, meta-analyses showed that interventions lacking direct support from a counselor (e.g., self-exploration, computer programs) were significantly less effective than interventions that included a direct contact with a qualified counselor (Whiston, Brecheisen, & Stephens, 2003; Whiston et al., 1998). The most current meta-analysis on this topic (Whiston et al., 2003) also reports that various types of interventions are associated with different levels of effectiveness. However, often these differences were not statistically significant. Significant differences in the mean value of effectiveness appeared however between unstructured group counseling (where there is a freely held discussion about certain topics) and structured workshops, which, after the analyses of Whiston and colleagues (2003), prove to be significantly more effective. This may be the case because well-designed structured interventions contain more elements that make career interventions particularity effective (see more on this below) (Whiston et al., 2003). Additionally, the study reported a significant variance in the effects of the career workshops. This suggests that a positive mean effect for a certain kind of intervention (e.g., workshops) does not automatically make all interventions of that kind similarly effective.

Other studies examined the influence of the duration of a career intervention on its effectiveness. Somewhat surprisingly, meta-analyses (Whiston et al., 2003; Whiston et al., 1998) found no linear relation between the duration of an intervention and its effectiveness. Hence, longer career interventions might not automatically be more effective. The biggest effect size was found for interventions with a duration of nine or ten sessions (Whiston et al., 1998). However, another meta-analysis on this topic (Brown & Ryan Krane, 2000) showed that the clients' subjective evaluation of the efficacy of career counseling increased strongly with every session, reached its peak with the fourth or fifth session, and fell dramatically afterwards. Therefore, from the client's point of view, a counseling process with four or five sessions showed the highest efficacy.

These results have many important implications for career counseling practice. They reveal that short interventions also can achieve solid effects if they are well-planned and structured. Thus, especially structured workshops seem to be an effective and cost-effective intervention form for many clients. Furthermore, the results of these studies point to the central role of the counselor for an intervention to be effective. Interventions where clients worked all by themselves, using self-exploration activates or websites, were distinctively less effective than working with a counselor in person. Moreover, the results imply that the

biggest effects in the shortest time possible can be achieved by individual career counseling. However, if the focus lays on assisting as many people as possible with limited resources, group interventions, specifically in the form of structured workshops, should be applied.

4.3 Effectiveness of life design interventions

While most existing intervention research was conducted with more of a career guidance framework, recent research has also started to investigate the effectiveness of interventions based on the life design paradigm. Life design has been applied to diverse age groups, and an increasing number of publications have reported the usefulness of life design interventions across various populations, ranging from young (Masdonati & Fournier, 2015) to older adults (Froidevaux, submitted). Some studies reported the effectiveness of life design interventions through increased career adaptability, among Italian middle school students using an online life design career intervention group (Nota, Santilli, & Soresi, 2016), and among South African adolescents using group-based life design counseling sessions (Maree & Symington, 2015). Other studies reported beneficial results of life design interventions on career decision-making: A decrease in career decision-making difficulties (i.e., lack of information and inconsistent information) and an increase in career decision-making self-efficacy were reported among Italian entrepreneurs, using group-based life design counseling sessions (i.e., career-story interview) (Di Fabio & Maree, 2012); a decrease in career indecision, and an increase in readiness for making career decisions about an academic major among US undergraduate students using a life-design group (LDG) (Barclay & Stoltz, 2016); and an improvement in vocational certainty–but not in career maturity–in the case of an adolescent using life-design counseling (Cardoso, Goncalves, Duarte, Silva, & Alves, 2016).

4.4 Effectiveness of certain career intervention elements

Given the large array of different career interventions conducted, an important question to address is whether effective career interventions share some common elements. Several studies showed that in psychological counseling more generally, factors such as clients' abilities, strengths, or attitudes in addition to a solid counseling relationship (i.e., working alliance) between counselor and client are vital for the effectives of counseling (Ahn & Wampold, 2001). This suggests that which specific counseling techniques or models are applied seems to be less important for a successful counseling. In fact, diverse authors (e.g., Corey, 1996) emphasized a real, emphatic, and respectful relationship between the counselor and the client in the sense of (Rogers, 1951), as the most important factor for the success and effectiveness of any counseling. In career counseling specifically, several studies (e.g., Anderson & Niles, 2000; Masdonati, Massoudi, & Rossier, 2009; Masdonati, Perdrix,

Massoudi, & Rossier, 2014) found that adult clients considered the emotional support provided by the counselor as well as a positive working relationship as the most crucial factors for the success in career counseling.

Despite the importance of these more general elements, a meta-analysis (Brown & Ryan Krane, 2000) concluded that certain elements make a career intervention especially effective. Specifically, five elements of effective interventions were identified, which, when included in career interventions, are able to enhance the effect of the intervention significantly:

1. Clients reflect upon and write down their career and life goals (e.g., by having an exercise book or by the application of written exercises);
2. Counselors provide individual interpretations and feedback to the clients (e.g., based on test results);
3. Counselors provide current information about the work of work and support clients in obtaining such information outside of the counseling session;
4. Clients learn about effective career behavior by models and mentors; and
5. Counselors help clients to develop supportive networks to help them achieve their career goals.

A follow-up study by (Brown et al., 2003) confirmed that these five elements are indeed the most critical factors for having a large impact with a career intervention. As their meta-analysis showed, the mere addition of random elements (true to the motto: “more is always better”) could not show any such effects. However, the efficacy of interventions increased almost in a linear way the more of these five elements it contained. Hence, the elements of effective interventions identified by Brown and colleagues (2003) are an important point of reference when planning and conducting career interventions.

5 Conclusions and Avenues for Future Research

Career counseling as a specific application of psychology and as part of the broader field of counseling psychology represents a divers array of types of career interventions in which diverse groups of clients are supported in various concerns about educational, vocational, and career issues. Among others, the scientific literature on career guidance and counseling contains models that focus on how to structure a guidance and counseling process, how to assist clients in their career decision-making, as well as how to help clients construct a meaningful career identity. Also, the effectiveness of different career interventions is

relatively well documented. However, research on career counseling effectiveness focused mainly on results such as career decidedness, knowledge about careers, or planning clarity. Future research should also increasingly examine how important aspects of modern career theories could be promoted by career counseling, such as a protean career orientation (Hall, 2004), social-cognitive aspects of career self-management (Lent, 2013), or personal and environmental career resources (Hirschi, 2012). Therefore, future research should focus on the effectiveness and processes of interventions based on recent career development and career counseling theories to identify which kind of intervention achieves what kind of short- and long-term outcomes with what kind of clients.

This seems especially true for the life-design paradigm. Since its introduction (Savickas et al., 2009), research and practice in career counseling within the life design paradigm has grown rapidly. However, three open questions remain regarding future research in this area. First, many forms of life design interventions have emerged (i.e., individual and group settings, specific booklets or interviews) and a variety of methods have been used to measure their effectiveness (i.e., questionnaires, thematic content analyses, case-studies). Thus, it is important to avoid confusion stemming from a growing number of interventions that refer to the life design paradigm but use very different methods and processes. Second, despite the initial support of its effectiveness reported above, there is a need to identify specific outcome criteria according to which career counselors may assess whether clients have defined a clearer view of themselves, or have implemented concrete actions that are closer to their life portrait and core values (Cohen-Scali & Kokosowski, 2010). Finally, while career guidance and career counseling are recognized to co-exist in the career counseling practice (Savickas, 2012), it is necessary to define more precisely the criteria that would determine in which situation and for which client to focus on one or the other approach. For instance, Cohen-Scali and Kokosowski (2010) have argued that life design interventions were not only lengthy and demanding for clients, but that the reliance on dialog and self-reflection might limit its applicability to many populations (e.g., those with lower levels of education or immigration background) and counseling settings (e.g., short term interventions).

The challenge for the future practical application of career counseling is to continue developing professional standards and to apply them in a broad range on a global scale. For this, the profession of career counseling possesses valuable experience over decades and profound research. These advantages should be specifically integrated in career counseling education and practice. Additionally, the training of career counselors based on modern approaches of career development and counseling–and integrating recent scientific knowledge

about career development, should be continuously improved and developed. In this way, career counseling will thrive as a field of research and practice that encompasses many competencies, processes, and lines of scientific research–and ought not to be restricted to being a simple placement service helping clients to choose a career or find employment.

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